The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump suspended his threat to strike **Iran's** energy infrastructure for a further ten days, until April 6th. He had previously given Friday as his deadline for negotiations. He said this was at the request of Iran's government, and insisted that talks were ongoing. Earlier Iran delivered its response to Mr Trump's peace plan. It reportedly demanded compensation for war damage and recognition of Iran's sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz—both non-starters.

Stockmarkets slid amid conflicting messages from Mr Trump and Iran over negotiations. America's S&P 500 fell by 1.7%, its largest drop since the war began. The NASDAQ lost 2.4%. Asian bourses also dipped in early trading. **Oil prices** fell slightly after Mr Trump backed down on striking Iranian energy targets. Brent crude was selling for $107 a barrel.

A federal judge in **America** blocked the Trump administration from blacklisting **Anthropic**. Earlier this month officials had labelled the AI firm as a supply-chain risk after it refused to grant the Pentagon unrestricted use of its technology in wars. The judge said the "arbitrary and capricious" designation would "cripple" the firm.

The Trump administration is expected to appeal against the decision.

Vladimir Putin reportedly asked **Russian oligarchs** to donate to the country's dwindling budget. According to the *Financial Times*, Russia's president is determined to carry on fighting in Ukraine despite the financial strain. Defence spending increased to 15.6trn roubles ($186.2bn) in 2025, around 7% of GDP. Russia's billionaires are unlikely to refuse Mr Putin's "request".

Pernod Ricard, a French spirits-maker, said it was discussing a merger with Brown-Forman, the firm that owns **Jack Daniels**, America's largest whisky producer. Pernod said that if the deal went ahead it "would be akin to a merger of equals". Both firms have been hit hard by a slump in demand for their booze.

The **International Olympic Committee** banned **transgender** women from women's events. The organisation will use a test for a gene known as SRY, which determines male sex, to uphold the rule. It said its decision "protects fairness, safety and integrity". Previously the committee had allowed individual sports to decide whether transgender athletes could compete at the games.

Last winter's **Arctic sea ice** was the smallest ever recorded for the second year in a row, according to analysis published by America's national satellite and ocean research agencies. The sea ice around the North Pole peaked at around 14m square kilometres, more than 2m square kilometres lower than the maximum extent recorded when records began in 1979, a reduction equivalent in size to Greenland.

Figure of the day: 22m, the number of people in the Middle East who live within 1km of a reported strike. Read our report on the human toll of the Iran war.

Photograph: Reuters

Wavering support for America's war

When foreign ministers of the G7 meet outside Paris on Friday, they will expect some insight from the American secretary of state, Marco Rubio. What comes after a month of conflict in the Middle East: a hollow victory, desperate negotiations or a reckless escalation?

The answer will influence how far America's allies are willing to go to help re-open the Strait of Hormuz. Donald Trump has veered from asking them to send ships to denouncing them as "cowards" for not responding, and telling them they are not needed anyway. He has even suggested leaving the strait for others to deal with. "At a certain point it'll open itself," Mr Trump said recently.

After Mr Trump's tariffs, threats to seize Greenland and courtship of Russia, their patience is thin. They were not consulted about the war. Yet European countries and Japan depend on the Gulf's oil and gas exports. And they have no better solution than Mr Trump does.

Photograph: Getty Images

Japan’s balancing act over Iran

Japan has a lot to lose from a blocked Strait of Hormuz. In normal times, more than 90% of its imported crude oil transits the waterway. This week Japan began releasing oil from its strategic reserve. After the oil crisis in the 1970s, it built one of the largest stockpiles in the world, equivalent to 254 days of consumption. This time, 80m barrels (enough to last around 45 days) will be released.

The war loomed large over last week’s summit between Japan’s prime minister, Takaichi Sanae, and Donald Trump. Mr Trump called on allies to send warships to help open the strait. Ms Takaichi pandered to Mr Trump by promising to buy Alaskan oil, but deftly sidestepped the question of naval support. Japan has historically had relatively warm relations with Iran, potentially providing a useful diplomatic channel. This week, Iran signalled it would allow Japanese vessels to pass safely through the strait. But the offer may not go down well with Mr Trump.

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s vibe-cession deepens

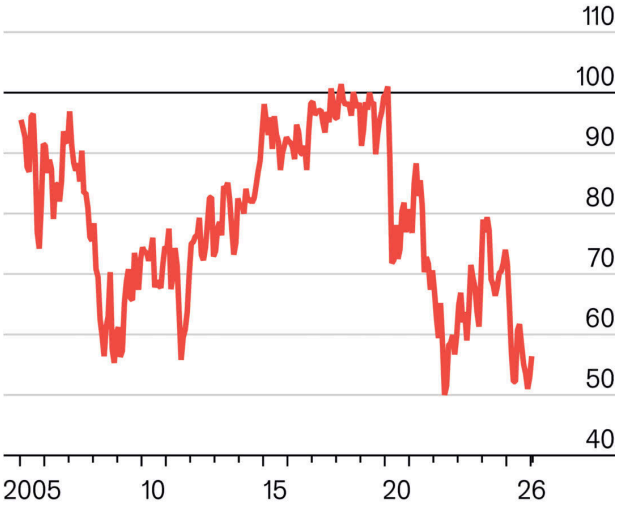
Even before Donald Trump went to war, Americans were glum. The University of Michigan’s barometer of consumer sentiment, out on Friday, is not far from its lowest reading in its 70-year history. A rival measure from the Conference Board, a business body, is a little cheerier, but is still plumbing depths last recorded during the covid lockdowns.

That dour mood persisted despite robust economic data. GDP growth was strong, unemployment fairly low. Inflation wasn’t quite tamed, but settled below post-pandemic extremes. Worries about a recession in 2023-24, because of rising interest rates, and in 2025, because of Mr Trump’s tariffs, proved unfounded.

There are plenty of theories for the gap between feelings and figures: the lingering effect of high prices; social-media angst; distaste for high interest rates; spillover from the negativity of politics. Whatever the cause, the war is set to widen it. Petrol prices are up sharply. Americans hate few things more than paying extra at the pump.

In the doldrums

United States, consumer-sentiment index, 1966=100



Source: University of Michigan

Photograph: Getty Images

Raye’s ambitious next act

Raye, a British soul and R&B singer, was far from unknown when the lead single of her second album, “Where Is My Husband!”, went viral in 2025. The 28-year-old, who has drawn comparisons to Amy Winehouse, a singer who died in 2011, picked up a record haul of six Brit awards the previous year.

Raye’s new record, “This Music May Contain Hope” is released on Friday. A 73-minute concept album revolving around the four seasons, it is epic in its scope and ambition, moving beyond the TikTok-pleasing soundbites that propelled her to a new level of stardom. The album harks back to the orchestral 1960s style of Shirley Bassey, a Welsh belter of notes, while embracing modern pop. Its quality vindicates her choice to pursue her own vision after she felt stifled on a big label. Perhaps that should come as no surprise. As she said when winning her Brits in 2024: “I’m in control. I’m my own boss”.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What is the name of the Islamic equivalent of the Red Cross?

Thursday: In poker, what is the term for a hand that contains three of a kind and a pair?

War is an absolute failure of imagination, scientific and political.

Adrienne Rich